Board 1 South Deals None Vul	♠ 6 3 ♥ A J 10 ♦ A 6 3 ♣ A 9 8 4 2	
♠ K 9 5 2 ♥ 9 ♦ K Q J 9 ♣ Q J 7 5	N W E S	♠ A J 10 8 4 ♥ 4 3 ♦ 10 7 4 ♣ K 10 3
	♠ Q 7 ♥ K Q 8 7 6 5 2 ♦ 8 5 2 ♣ 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South

Responding to preempts is easy. You don't count points, you just count tricks. Assume partner for 6 tricks and add yours to see how high to go (or not go).

Here, with three Aces and a possible ♠ ruff you raise to game.

North would play 4♥.

Click

South plays 4♥. East leads the ♦K.

Things look grim. The defense has exposed your ♦ losers already and those two ♠ losers seem pretty obvious also. If you are to make this contract you must do so before you lose the lead. That means you must establish the ♣ suit **NOW**.

Win the ♦A, play ♣A and ruff the ♣2 with a high trump. Play a ♥ to the ♥10 and ruff the ♣4 with a high trump. Play a ♥ to the ♥J and ruff the ♣8 with a high trump. Play a ♥ to the ♥A and discard a loser on the good ♣9.

It took a 4-3 ♣ split to make this contract.

Fortunately that occurs a high percentage of the time. In any case, there was no other hope.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	North	
	♠ K 8 6 ♥ A 8 4 ♦ A Q 8 ♣ Q J 10 7	
West ♠ Q 9 7 3 ♥ J 7 2 ♦ 9 6 5 ♣ 8 6 2	N W E S	**East** ♠ A 4 2 ♥ 10 9 5 3 ♦ 7 4 2 ♣ 5 4 3
	South ♠ J 10 5 ♥ K Q 6 ♦ K J 10 3 ♣ A K 9	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	4NT	Pass	6NT
All Pass			

6NT by South

You have 16 points - a pretty solid 16 in fact. Partner has 15, 16 or 17, so together you have 31, 32 or 33. You want to invite partner to bid 6NT if he has 17, but to decline if he has 15. The correct bid for this invitation is 4NT. It is called a "quantitative" 4NT since it is just an invitational raise. It is **NOT** Blackwood - if you wanted to ask for Aces you would use Gerber.

Partner bids the slam.

North would play 6NT.

Click

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠3.

South plays 6NT. West leads the ♠3.

Winner count: ♠ 0 : ♥ 3 : ♦ 4 : ♣ 4 : Total = 11

It's pretty clear which suit you have to worry about! Your goal is simple, you must win one ♠ trick before you lose two. So the crux of your problem is: Who holds the ♠A and ♠Q?

If West has both of them you are guaranteed to win the first trick no matter what you play.

If East has both of them you are going to lose the first two tricks no matter what you play.

The problem is to decide what to do if they are split. The answer relies on psychology, not on probability. West has made an attacking lead. But if you were West would you start out leading a low ♠ from a suit like ♠ A 9 7 3? That would be incredibly foolhardy, you would probably lead a different suit and save your ♠A for catching something high from declarer. On the other hand you would be quite likely to lead a small card from ♠ Q 9 7 3.

Your PLAN should be to play low in dummy and win your ♠10 if East withholds the ♠A.

If you think West has ♠ A 9 7 3 then you should play the ♠K from dummy. But if you think West has ♠ Q 9 7 3 you should play low from dummy.

Since West is unlikely to underlead an Ace against 6NT you play East for the ♠A.